for its use of fine flour and ghee, in addition to serving a sweet dish of rice boiled in milk. Akbar was impressed with the food, and the number of people fed at the langar, for the followers of the Guru had increased rapidly, attracting men and women of all classes and backgrounds because of his egalitarian message of brotherhood, love, humility, and a God above all earthly distinctions. Akbar too was impressed with the order and wanted to make an offering to the Guru, who refused the offer.

After finally settling affairs at Lahore, Akbar and the Mughal camp headed back to Agra. North of Delhi, near Kurukshetra, the Mughal party camped outside a town called Thaneshwar. There was a large tank with a pavilion in the middle and hundreds of yogis and ascetics of different sects had gathered for a pilgrimage. The ascetics were a fearsome collection of men, bare-chested, with large, lopsided topknots, faces cloudy with ashes, and carrying swords, bows and arrows, and sticks. A large number of pilgrims had arrived too. A dispute arose between two sects, the ascetic Sannyasis and the tantric Naths, described by Abu'l Fazl as the Puris and the Kaurs. As the bemused Mughal party watched, the sadhus began to argue over the best spot from which to collect alms from the pilgrims. Akbar tried to reason with the men but it was like 'casting pearls into the dust'. The men grew angrier and demanded to be allowed to fight each other which Akbar eventually agreed to. Both groups lined up to face each other and one man from each sect swaggered up, sword drawn, to fight the other. In an instant, all the yogis had rushed at each other in a terrible melee of flailing limbs and smashing stones and swishing swords. Akbar watched the proceedings with keen interest and when he saw that one side, the Puris, were outnumbered, he sent some of his own followers to join in and balance out the fight. The Kaurs were then roundly defeated with their chief, one Anand Kaur, 'ground into the dust'. The Padshah, we are told, 'thoroughly enjoyed the spectacle'. That Akbar was fascinated by this encounter with the yogis, as he would be later in life, too, is borne out by paintings made of the episode in at least four separate biographies of the time.

Once the imperial train had reached Agra, Akbar was confronted with a delicate problem. One of his officers, Jalal Khan Qurchi, was seized with passion for a 'beautiful youth and was immoderate with regard to him'. Very annoyed, Akbar attempted to separate the two men but then Jalal Khan Qurchi ran away with the youth. Akbar had them caught and brought back to court and Jalal Khan was 'confined under the public staircase so that he